

Why We Sometimes Start With Less Exercise Than You Think You Can Do

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You've just started a new exercise program and your Exercise Physiologist tells you to do a 10-minute walk.

Your first thought might be:

"Ten minutes? I could easily do 30."

And you might be right.

But being **capable of doing something once** and being able to **consistently tolerate it** are two different things.

At Valen Health, we sometimes deliberately prescribe less exercise than you think you can manage. It's not because we think you're incapable. It's because finding the right starting point can help you build strength, fitness and physical capacity without constantly battling excessive soreness, fatigue or symptom flare-ups.

Your maximum isn't always the best starting point

Imagine you can walk for 30 minutes — but afterwards your pain increases significantly and you need the rest of the day to recover.

Technically, you *can* walk for 30 minutes.

But is 30 minutes the right exercise dose for you right now?

Probably not.

Instead, we might start with 10 or 15 minutes. If you can complete that comfortably, recover well and repeat it consistently, we have something to build on.

Exercise prescription isn't about finding the absolute maximum you can tolerate.

It's about finding the right amount to create positive change without overwhelming your current capacity.

We care about what happens after exercise

How you feel *during* exercise is only part of the picture.

As Exercise Physiologists, we're also interested in what happens later that day, the following morning and sometimes even over the next few days.

Did your symptoms settle quickly?

Were you able to continue with your normal activities?

Did you sleep well?

Could you exercise again when planned?

Or did that one session leave you so sore, fatigued or symptomatic that you needed several days to recover?

If your exercise program repeatedly leaves you unable to function normally afterwards, it may be difficult to build consistency.

That's why your starting point can sometimes feel surprisingly manageable.

More exercise isn't always better

Exercise works by providing your body with a challenge and then allowing it to adapt.

But the challenge needs to be appropriate.

Too little stimulus may not create the changes we're looking for. Too much may cause excessive soreness, fatigue, symptom flare-ups or prolonged recovery.

We're looking for the **“just right” dose**.

That might mean adjusting:

- How long you exercise
- How hard you exercise
- How much weight you lift
- How many exercises you complete
- How many sets and repetitions you perform
- How frequently you train
- How much recovery you have between sessions

The goal is not necessarily to make every session harder.

The goal is to provide enough challenge to encourage adaptation while still allowing you to recover.

Starting with less helps us learn how your body responds

This can be particularly important when someone is returning to exercise after an injury, surgery, illness or a long period of inactivity, or when they're living with persistent pain, fatigue or a chronic health condition.

Your Exercise Physiologist may have a good idea of where to start based on your assessment, but every person responds differently.

Starting conservatively gives us useful information.

If you tolerate the exercise well, great — we can progress.

If your symptoms increase significantly, we can modify the program without having pushed you too far in the first place.

Think of your first few sessions as an opportunity to **learn what your body can currently tolerate**, rather than a test of everything it is capable of doing.

The aim is progression, not restriction

Being asked to start with less can sometimes feel frustrating, particularly if you're eager to get back to your previous level of activity.

But a conservative starting point isn't where we intend you to stay.

We might gradually increase your walking time, add another set, increase the resistance, introduce another exercise or reduce your recovery periods.

Small increases performed consistently can add up to significant improvements over time.

In many cases:

Start manageable → recover well → repeat → progress

is far more effective than:

Start hard → flare up → stop → recover → start hard again.

Consistency gives us something to build on

One great workout isn't usually what creates meaningful improvements in your health.

It's what you can repeat over weeks and months that matters.

That's why we sometimes prescribe an amount of exercise that feels easier than expected at the beginning.

We're not just thinking about what you can do **today**.

We're thinking about what we can help you do next week, next month and beyond.

How can an Exercise Physiologist help?

An **Accredited Exercise Physiologist (AEP)** uses exercise as part of the management of a range of injuries, chronic health conditions and physical limitations.

At **Valen Health**, your Exercise Physiologist can assess your current capacity, symptoms and goals before developing an individualised exercise program. From there, your program can be progressively adjusted as your strength, fitness, confidence and tolerance improve.

Whether you're returning to exercise after an injury, managing persistent pain or fatigue, living with a chronic health condition, or simply unsure where to begin, the goal is to find a starting point that works for **you**.

Because sometimes doing a little less today is exactly what allows you to do a whole lot more tomorrow.

Want some guidance on where to start?

Book an Exercise Physiology appointment with the team at **Valen Health** and let us help you find the right starting point, build your capacity and work towards the activities that matter to you.